

Theorizing Employee Stress, Well-being, Resilience and Boundary Management in the Context of Forced Work from Home During COVID-19

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Abstract

The COVID-19 pandemic hit mankind at an unprecedented scale. In their attempt to continue functioning, organizations asked employees to work from home. Though employees experienced stress due to ‘forced’ work from home and blurring of work–family boundaries, they had to cope with the challenging times. The present study aimed to unearth the aspects of boundary management and adaptation in the context of work from home during the COVID-19 pandemic. Thus, we address the research question ‘how did the employees adapt to the sudden forced work from home during the COVID-19 pandemic?’ Since work from home was forced upon employees during the pandemic leading to the violation of boundaries, we invoked the *boundary theory* that highlights the boundaries that people draw between their personal and professional lives to maintain a balance. Further, we referred to the theory of cognitive adaptation to explain how employees adapted to the challenges while working from home during COVID-19. We conducted in-depth interviews of 30 experienced professionals working in the technology-enabled sectors in India. We applied Gioia’s methodology to analyse the qualitative data. Four aggregate dimensions emerged from the data analysis, as employees involuntarily worked from home: stress due to work disruptions, threats to employee well-being, boundary violation and employee resilience. Our findings contribute to the current theoretical understanding of employee stress, boundary management, adaptation or resilience and employee well-being, in the context of forced work from home. While employees were stressed and boundaries had blurred between work and family, they adapted and demonstrated resilience to the unprecedented changes in their lives. Practical implications of our study include managers’ conscious efforts towards respecting work–family boundaries, enhancing employee well-being and building a resilience-promoting work environment.

Keywords

COVID-19, work from home, employee stress, work–family boundaries, adaptation, resilience, well-being

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Work from Home During the Pandemic Era

Work from home (WFH) in the pre-pandemic era was an option for employees in a handful of industries and in a few kinds of jobs. Employees whose work was technology-driven and could work remotely without being physically present in the organizational campus could exercise this option of working from home, albeit for a specific number of days in a year. However, as the COVID-19 pandemic hit the globe and brought economic activities to a grinding halt, the only viable option for organizations and economies to survive was to ask all employees to WFH (Jaiswal & Arun, 2020b). Employees across industries and irrespective of their nature of work were forced to WFH. The scale and scope of WFH expanded unexpectedly and unprecedentedly. When employees themselves chose WFH in the pre-pandemic phase, they were aware of the conditions and implications of WFH. They could also estimate the duration of time after which work–life will become normal. However, during the pandemic when employees were suddenly forced to WFH, most employees were neither mentally nor physically prepared for this change. Moreover, the WFH phase extended for most employees to a couple of years due to multiple waves of the COVID-19 pandemic. Each wave brought along completely strange variants of the disease with new challenges. People were not fully aware of safety precautions but, at the same time, they knew that disease could be fatal, and no remedy was in sight. These factors heightened the anxiety level among the employees. Thus, WFH shifted from being a choice to a forced new normal for the way of work.

The extant literature on boundary management states that people have different preferences related to work–family interaction. The degree to which people prefer mixing work and family demands differs, and the degree to which people can tolerate the mix-up also differs. When employees willingly select WFH, they are aware of the fluidity of boundaries, and their ability to tolerate the permeability is also high. They also might have assessed the infrastructure and space requirement and acquired or organized resources accordingly. However, in the current context of WFH during COVID-19, several individual-level issues cropped up with regards to the mix-up of work and family demands for an indefinite period that kept on getting extended. While being confined to the physical home boundaries, employees had to manage both their personal and professional lives. In most cases, there was a blurring of boundaries leading to disruption of work–family boundary management. While proponents of WFH state that WFH ensured business continuity, accelerated the pace of technology adoption, revealed cost-cutting methods to organizations and opened avenues for virtual global collaboration (Malhotra, 2021), at an individual level, it created a wide spectrum of challenges for employees. On the personal front, managing household responsibilities, juggling between zoom-bombing (virtual meetings) and home-schooling, fighting the disease itself or keeping safe from contracting it and managing the uncertainties and negative news about the loss of lives and jobs took a toll on personal well-being. On the professional front, employees were concerned about their inability to WFH, performance outcomes, dipping engagement and motivation levels, compensation, career progression, (mis)communication and remote coordination. The global pandemic, thus, drastically, dramatically and expeditiously forced people to change the way they worked and created a disbalance in their work–family lives.

The past decade has witnessed several scholars deliberating on the changing face of work enabled by advanced technologies, such as artificial intelligence, automation and blockchain (Jaiswal et al., 2021; Malhotra, 2021). While the workforce globally was getting techno-future-ready, COVID-19 hit the entire globe with an unexpected jolt and brought economic activity to a grinding halt. As stated by Hoff (2021), the pandemic created ‘the most significant organization design shock of our lifetimes’ by forcing remote work for all and at all times (Ancona et al., 2021). Though employees continued to WFH during the COVID-19 pandemic, clearly, it was not a preferred work arrangement for a large part of the

workforce due to mismanagement of work–family boundaries. The turbulence in the personal and professional lives of people caused by the COVID-19 pandemic has brought forth pressing questions about how individuals adapted to the forced WFH scenario. Thus, the present study was driven by the key research question: How did the employees adapt to the sudden forced WFH during the COVID-19 pandemic?

Our study contributes to the extant literature in *two* ways. First, the literature on boundary management primarily focuses on employees who choose to work remotely. We extend the boundary management literature by exploring WFH as a ‘forced’ method of working for all employees (to the maximum extent possible) across the globe during the COVID-19 pandemic. Second, when WFH was suddenly thrust upon employees, they spent their initial days during the lockdown figuring out how to work and familiarizing themselves with this new work practice. As months passed by, while some employees started to feel disconnected, others counted on the positive aspects that emerged from the crisis. Our study explored how employees adapted to the various challenges they faced while working from home, thus, contributing to the growing literature on employee adaptation and resilience.

In the subsequent sections, we delve into the theoretical background that has helped in the emergence of the key research questions. We elaborate on the study design and analyse the data. We discuss our findings, theoretical contributions and present the implications of the study.

Theoretical Background

WFH, Boundary Management and Adaptation

With the advent of technology in the past few decades, WFH became possible and gradually gained acceptance in the service and technology sectors. WFH is the work that is undertaken by an employee outside of the traditional office setting but is connected to the office via information and communication technology (Lautsch et al., 2009). WFH enables employees to work from a location of their choice (mostly home) and at their preferred time (Golden et al., 2008). WFH is different from ‘work from anywhere’. Employees could not select work from anywhere because travel was not possible, and the only possible place to work was from home. The COVID-19 pandemic gave a thrust to the practice of WFH as most employees globally worked remotely. While in the initial weeks WFH was encouraged, it gradually became a forced phenomenon. One year into the pandemic, organizations realized that this was the most significant organization design shock as this scale and scope of remote work were not expected (Varma et al., 2022). This forced relocation of the place of work created a deep impact on the lives of individuals as it was not only unexpected but also people were unprepared for such a work modality. Thus, a deeper exploration of the ‘forced’ WFH phenomenon is warranted from the employee perspective.

As employees worked from home during the COVID-19 pandemic, the overlap between their personal and professional spaces increased. The boundaries between personal life and professional life became blurred, and the spillover of personal work during work hours and vice versa became unavoidable. The intrusion of personal and professional responsibilities into each other’s territory became more frequent and most often inevitable. Thus, we invoke the boundary theory (Nippert-Eng, 1996) which suggests that individuals have different levels of tolerance towards the level of permeability in boundaries. Further, how they treat the spillover depends on the individual’s preference for boundary management. However, we believe that the theoretical understanding of adaptation and boundary management is limited to

normal times and needs to be extended to crisis times such as the COVID-19 pandemic. This is because the philosophy of boundary management is valid only when employees have a voice with regard to their work–family boundaries. When employees choose to WFH, their service conditions and organizational association are quite different from when they are forced to WFH. In the present study context, employees did not have a choice to voice out their preferences regarding managing their personal and professional boundaries. Inadvertent boundary violations were inevitable; thus, the current theoretical lens of boundary management is insufficient to address such situations of boundary violations.

While blurring of boundaries created chaos in the lives of employees, they had no choice but to cope with the unexpected work–life situation brought about by the pandemic. Employees had to adapt cognitively while living through the threatening COVID-19 pandemic and forcibly working from home. In this connection, the theory of cognitive adaptation (Taylor, 1983) borrowed from the field of nursing, may help employees to manage the work–family boundary violations. However, this theory is also limited in its scope. It highlights people's immediate response to the crisis and how they adapt, however, managers need to understand how they can help employees not only adapt to the crisis but also thrive in the face of adversity. Thus, the present study aims to extend the two theories by understanding how employees managed the boundary violations and adapted to the forced WFH scenario.

Method

For the purpose of the study, we interviewed 30 employees working in technology-enabled sectors in India. We used purposive sampling and chose respondents who had more than three years of work experience because these respondents would have worked from home for 1.5 years during the pandemic and would have been employed for a minimum period of 1.5 years in the pre-pandemic period. We deemed this tenure of working from the organizational premises as an important criterion because employees take some time to get familiarized with the business functioning and the work environment. Hence, a fresh graduate from college or an employee who has not spent enough time working physically from the office may not be a fit respondent for the present study. Data were collected between May and June 2021.

While the pandemic forced employees across all industries to WFH, a major portion of the manufacturing sector workforce could not WFH as the nature of their work necessitated them to be physically present. However, in the case of technology-enabled sectors, WFH could be implemented for most of the workforce. Hence, the present study focused on respondents from technology-enabled sectors, such as information technology, consultancy and banking. Respondents spanned different industrial and metropolitan locations in India.

After briefing the professionals about the purpose of the study, we sought an appointment to conduct the interviews on Zoom, a videoconferencing and communication platform. All respondents were assured that the anonymity of their responses will be maintained. The key questions driving the interviews were around their experiences with the practice of WFH, their connection with the organization and organizational members as they worked virtually, and how they coped with the challenges of WFH. The Appendix provides the interview schedule. We refrained from using any leading words to ensure that the respondents' remained unbiased.

We also collected data on their gender, age, industry, pre-COVID-19 work location, current work location, age, total work experience, tenure in the current organization and current designation. We enquired about the respondents' current work mode and preferred work mode in the post-pandemic phase. Each interview lasted for 25–30 minutes. With the permission of the respondents, the interviews

were recorded and transcribed within 24 hours. We reached theoretical saturation with the study's sample size as repetitive themes started emerging. Table 1 describes the respondents' characteristics. The pre-COVID-19 work location was Chennai, Bangalore, Kolkata, Mumbai and Gurugram for most of the respondents whereas their location at the time of this study was primarily their home town including Chennai, Ranchi, Patna, Kolkata and Mumbai. The current roles of the respondents included analytics, finance, human resources and technology.

We also sought data from the respondents on questions such as home-schooling children, spouse WFH, parents living together and the number of rooms in the house. These data were collected to have a deeper understanding of the environment in which people worked from home. Further, we asked the respondents if they purchased any devices (such as laptops), furniture, internet connection and power backup, in order to smoothly and comfortably WFH. It is observed that 33% of the respondents had home-schooling children, 27% of their spouses were also working from home, most of them had their parents co-living, and most of them lived in a three-bedroom house. Further, 80% of the respondents had to buy a laptop or tablet to WFH while 94% bought some ergonomic furniture to work comfortably. All the respondents shared that they had to set up high-speed internet connections and power backup systems to work without any technical interruptions.

Table 1. Respondents' Characteristics

Characteristics	Number of Respondents (n = 30)
Gender	
Male	19
Female	11
Age Groups	
Less than or equal to 40	25
Greater than 40	5
Industry	
Information technology	16
Banking and insurance	7
Consultancy	6
Telecommunication	1
Work Experience	
Between 3 and 10 years	22
Greater than or equal to 10 years	8
Tenure in the Current Organization	
Less than five years	23
Greater than or equal to five years	7
Current Work Mode	
Hybrid	5
On-site	1
WFH	24
Preferred Future Work Mode	
Hybrid	22
On-site	6
WFH	2

Source: The authors.

Data Analysis

Qualitative methods enable researchers, to explore a relevant phenomenon in-depth explore the reasons for its occurrence and provide a conceptual understanding of the phenomenon (Austin & Sutton, 2014; Williams & Moser, 2019). Since the present study was inductive in nature, we analysed the responses using Gioia's methodology (Gioia et al., 2013). Post finalizing the research question, we conducted the interviews, and several terms, codes and categories emerged from the participants' responses. This stage is referred to as first-order concepts by Gioia et al. (2013) wherein the researchers strictly stick to the terms and phrases used by the study participants and do not attempt to draw categories. As several interviews happen, the researchers begin to discover similarities and differences among the views shared by the respondents, thus, creating meaningful clusters. This stage is called second-order themes that elevate the participants' thoughts to a theoretical level and help the researchers in describing and explaining the study phenomenon. As the first-order concepts and second-order themes culminate into theoretical saturation (Glaser & Strauss, 1967), we proceed to distil aggregate dimensions. The three stages namely, first-order concepts, second-order themes and aggregate dimensions become the basis for building the 'data structure' for the study (Figure 1).

As researchers construct the data structure, they are compelled to think about the data theoretically, thus, bringing rigour to qualitative research. The data structure is not only a powerful data visualization tool but it also provides a graphical journey of how the researchers progressed from first-order raw interview data to second-order theoretical construction of themes to the final stage of meaningful aggregate dimensions that answer research questions (Amanbayev et al., 2021; Biswas et al., 2021; Jaiswal et al., 2021). Thus, qualitative data analysis conducted through Gioia's methodology provides a nuanced understanding of the aspects shared by the participants regarding the study phenomenon.

Findings

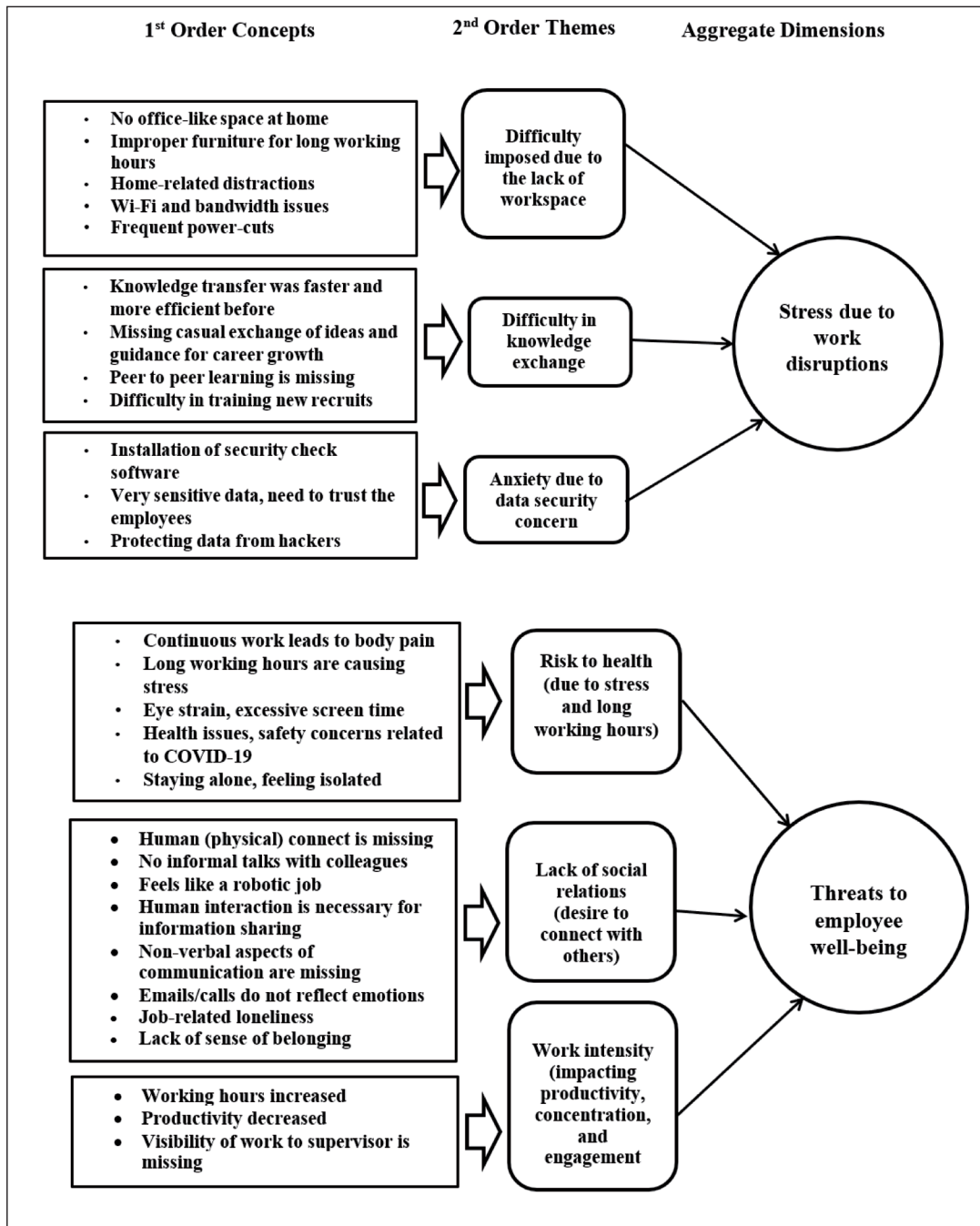
We set out to examine the current stance of employees on the phenomenon of WFH during the COVID-19 pandemic, and how they coped with the challenges of working from home. Table 2 provides the themes, dimensions and representative quotations from the respondents.

Next, we discuss our study findings in the context of the extant literature, and subsequently, we highlight our contribution to the extant body of knowledge.

Dimension 1: Stress Due to Work Disruptions

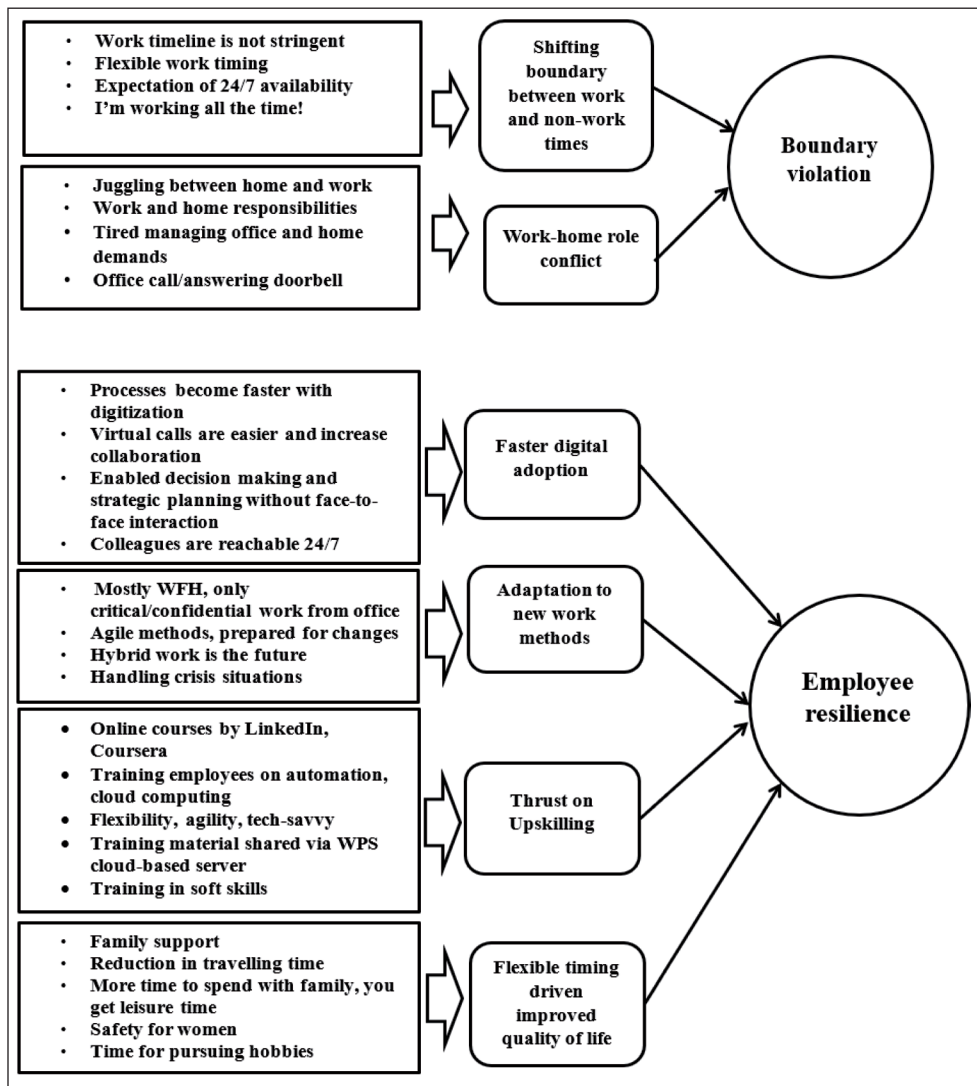
Difficulty Imposed Due to the Lack of Workspace

Several factors lead to the disruption of work, and thus, caused people a lot of stress as they worked from home. Prior to the pandemic when employees worked from home, it was their choice, i.e. voluntary. However, during the pandemic, organizations forced employees to WFH, i.e. involuntary. Employees did not have the adequate technological and physical infrastructure. Most employees had company-provided laptops, however, having a laptop was not enough for smooth work functioning. Poor internet connectivity was the biggest handicap as reported by most participants. Initially, employees managed with mobile data and hotspots, however, they faced severe bandwidth problems. At the time when COVID-19 was at its peak in 2020, it was difficult to purchase a broadband connection too. Moreover,



(Figure 1 continued)

(Figure 1 continued)

**Figure 1.** Data Structure**Source:** The authors.

setting up the broadband connection incurred a considerable cost. Further, participants reported frequent power cuts, and they did not have adequate power backups.

Lack of proper physical workspace in homes also caused disrupted work and caused stress. Most participants hailed from middle-class families who typically live in a two–three-room set-up. With all family members (including children) at home, the study participants could not create an office-like environment at home. Moreover, the furniture of a typical household is not such that it facilitates long

Table 2. Data Supporting the Data Structure's Themes and Dimensions

Sl. No.	Dimensions and Themes	Representative Direct Quotations	Previous Work
1	Stress due to Work Disruptions		
a	Difficulty imposed due to the lack of workspace	'Most of the time because of the bandwidth issues or Wifi issues, we face difficulty during the virtual connect.' (#9) 'I don't have a proper table and chair to work for long hours....forget that, I don't have a peaceful place in my house to conduct my virtual meetings.' (#26)	Pre-pandemic literature does not highlight these themes and dimensions in the context of WFH. Recent works of Jalali et al. (2021) and Purwanto et al. (2020) in the context of WFH during the pandemic converge with our findings, thus signifying our contribution.
b	Difficulty in knowledge exchange	'If the learner is not actively involved then the whole program falls flat because ultimately the knowledge transfer is not happening.' (#22) 'New buddies not comfortable with this online thing. I'm giving them training. They're hesitant to ask questions, which is not good for their future.' (#18)	
c	Anxiety due to data security concerns	Our company installed a software called SPWS utility... that will monitor all your activities, it'll notify you in case of any security breach...that is an important thing the company did on the security perspective.' (#11) 'Data hacking is very common...we have seen it so many times in the news....work from home situation makes it ripe situation for hackers to hack company data and important security data....so data security is a big concern for us.' (#19)	
2	Threats to Employee Well-being		
a	Risk to health (due to stress and long working hours)	'If this work from home goes on for a long time, the main issue which will arise is health issue.' (#14) 'Stress-wise, yeah, it is a bit more stressful...because the workload has increased a lot...more than what you can handle.' (#29) 'At office, we used to chat with our colleagues, have some tea breaks or lunch break....we will be moving to the meeting rooms, and we will have some breaks during the meetings...these breaks will increase our energy and relax us but now we are moving from one virtual meeting to another without any break.' (#22)	Ashforth (2020), Galanti et al. (2021) Golden et al. (2008), Hoff (2021), Jaiswal and Dyaram (2020a)
b	Lack of social relations (desire to connect with others)	'I miss chatting with my office friends, the lunchtime, sharing our problems.... now I can't share my feelings or emotions with anyone.' (#14) 'I'm not able to meet my manager, I'm not able to meet my subordinates, I'm not able to meet my colleagues, I cannot discuss my problem with HR face-to-face. These are the elements which I miss a lot.' (#19) 'Suppose I have a doubt, I just can't call up a colleague....I have to ask if he is free or not....in office, you just walk up to his place....or if the person sits next to you, just poke him!' (#17)	

(Table 2 continued)

(Table 2 continued)

Sl. No.	Dimensions and Themes	Representative Direct Quotations	Previous Work
c	Work intensity (impacting productivity, concentration and work engagement)	'I personally feel that when I was in office, I was much more productive, could concentrate much more concentrated and think in a straight way about my work....now I am working all the time but not very productive.' (#10) 'Constantly sitting on a chair and working for a long time....too much use of mobile....working hours have increased but I feel my productivity has decreased.' (#3) 'How to manage your work, how to create visibility in the eyes of your supervisor, these things are clearly missing.' (#8)	
3	Boundary Violation		
a	Shifting boundary between work and non-work times	'Now I am on calls at any time of the day...before I worked from 9–7...once I came home, no work but now even at 10 pm, I am attending calls.' (#13) 'My boss says half an hour of call only...on a Saturday... anyway you are at home!' (#17) 'Once you start working from home, you get a laptop from the company then the manager starts to expect that you should be available all the time.' (#15)	Cruz and Meisenbach (2018), Derks et al. (2016), Nippert-Eng (1996), Shumate and Fulk (2004)
b	Work-home role conflict	'I am juggling between home and work all the time.' (#1) 'I will be on a call and if the doorbell rings, I have to rush to take the deliveries.' (#30)	
4	Employee Resilience		
a	Faster digital adoption	'There was technology available but companies were reluctant to adopt them for reasons like data security, or lack of trust in employees. This pandemic has taught us to use technology to overcome the challenges of work during pandemic.' (#7) 'Virtual platforms help us to preserve data, manage data and processes have become more efficient in these times.' (#12) 'Virtual platforms are instrumental for important decision making....now you can take any decision without being face-to-face.' (#10)	Authors' contribution while extending the theory of cognitive adaptation
b	Adaptation to new work methods	'My company has communicated that more than 80% of employees will be working from home....only for confidential projects, the company will not allow employees to work from home.' (#6) 'My company is planning that only 25% of employees who have critical work which cannot be done from the home should be employed at office.' (#2) 'I have been asked to work from the office twice a week and remaining days from home. I think the hybrid model will work best.' (#26)	

(Table 2 continued)

(Table 2 continued)

Sl. No.	Dimensions and Themes	Representative Direct Quotations	Previous Work
c	Thrust on upskilling	'I am taking online courses related to machine learning.... my manager told me to pick these kind of courses.' (#25) 'I think employees need to be trained on how to be more motivated...and work on their learning and growth which would help them to still remain in the game that is being changed by technology.' (#30) 'We are getting some training materials from our company via WPS cloud-based server....this is a web-based training and it is very useful in this pandemic situation.' (#21)	
d	Flexible timing-driven improved quality of life	'At home, I have the luxury of relaxing for 30 minutes or lie down for 30 minutes post-lunch, and then resume my work.' (#7) 'In WFH setting, we do not have to invest time in traveling, a lot of time gets saved.' (#18) 'I have more time to spend time with my family. I am able to see my daughter playing, studying, etc....and I can help her in school activities also.' (#13) 'I have started singing again...before I had no time but now, I can listen to my favorite songs and also sing along.' (#3)	

Source: The authors.

work hours. Offices have ergonomically designed physical workspaces and furniture, however, that physical set-up could not be recreated at home. Thus, the concept of a sacrosanct 'personal space' and 'professional space' was not available at home.

Difficulty in Knowledge Exchange

The office environment facilitates the quick exchange of information and knowledge, which was found to be difficult in the WFH set-up. The flow of information through new communication channels was not very smooth, and virtual calls were reported to be less efficient by some participants with respect to tacit knowledge exchange and casual advice that one gets in an office environment. In the workplace, one not only learns from the behaviour of their seniors but also learns from their peers. Thus, overt exchange of information and subtle learning opportunities are lost in the virtual work set-up. However, employees had to adapt to the limited methods available for knowledge exchange.

Anxiety due to Data Security Concerns

Some participants reported anxiety related to data security. Besides employee data, an organization has a lot of customer data and data from other stakeholders. In the pre-pandemic times, most of the data were accessed from within the physical space of the organization. However, during the pandemic, the data could not be contained and had to be shared with employees as they worked from home. This brought serious concerns related to confidentiality of data, data leakage and data hacking. These concerns have

also been reported in recent studies by Jalali et al. (2021) and Purwanto et al. (2020). This work-related disruption caused anxiety for most employees, however, given the physical closure of offices, employees had to adapt to newer methods of data security, and employers had to increase their levels of trust in employees manifold.

Dimension 2: Threats to Employee Well-being

Risk to Health (Due to Stress and Long Working Hours)

Several health issues were emerging due to WFH posing a threat to employee well-being. Lack of balance between work and personal life and long working hours on the screen led to eye and body strain as employees worked from home. In addition, disrupted communication and stretched coordination caused a lot of stress on employees. Further, if the employee was staying alone, loneliness caused stress. Fear and anxiety about the new variants of the coronavirus, news of rising COVID-19 cases and deaths and the fear of job loss due to the economic downturn added to the list of factors causing stress among employees.

Lack of Social Relations (Desire to Connect with Others)

Participants unequivocally spoke about the lack of human connection during WFH, and their desire to connect with others. They even reported that work felt robotic due to lack of interaction in physical space with colleagues, lack of humour and fun that naturally happened in the office. Due to the dynamic composition of virtual teams, team spirit, team bonding and sense of belongingness had reduced. Further, verbal and non-verbal communication had also been reduced. Despite virtual connections, there was a lack of engagement among team members, and networking outside the organization was getting tougher. Employees also reported feelings of job-related loneliness and isolation. Lack of social relations implies a threat to their overall well-being.

Work Intensity (Impacting Productivity, Concentration and Engagement)

Most employees reported increased work intensity, i.e. not only had the work increased but also the number of working hours had increased. However, frustratingly, there were reduced levels of productivity and engagement even when employees were investing more effort and more time into their work. A considerable amount of time was spent by the participants in virtual connections, overcoming communication and coordination challenges, whereas the actual work that determined productivity was getting impacted. Further, the visibility to the supervisor had decreased as only the outcome was visible to the supervisor and not the process of work. Achieving targets and demonstrating good performance outcomes were challenging for most employees as they adapted to new ways of working during the pandemic. Thus, these factors also had an impact on employee well-being.

Heightened stress during the pandemic threatened employees' well-being. The situation in which mass remote work happened, i.e. the outbreak of COVID-19, itself is a new phenomenon. A recent study by Galanti et al. (2021) found that job demands were positively related to WFH stress during COVID-19. In a similar vein, our study highlighted how new ways of working alongside managing household demands, future-related uncertainties and prolonged hours of exposure to the screen increased stress and physical strain among employees. Further, employees feared professional isolation (being out-of-sight would limit career growth) and social isolation (missed the informal interactions). Feelings of isolation raised employees' doubts about their self-efficacy, organizational identity and reduced a sense of

organizational belongingness (Ashforth, 2020; Jaiswal & Dyaram, 2020a). In addition to stress and isolation, people felt that their work intensity had increased. Even in the pre-pandemic era, the well-being of employees in the service sector was a matter of concern for employers (Jaiswal & Arun, 2020c). The present situation of COVID-19 and remote work has exacerbated those concerns. Thus, the employer's focus on the health and well-being of employees gains significance in this regard (Hoff, 2021).

Dimension 3: Boundary Violation

Shifting Boundary Between Work and Non-work Times

Most respondents shared that as they worked from home, they were unable to manage the boundaries between their personal and professional lives. During the pre-pandemic era, workdays and timings were largely defined, and a spillover was rare. When the employee returned home in the evening or on the weekends, there was not much spillover of work. However, in the present scenario, the work hours and days had become fluid. Respondents also shared that the managers and colleagues were not considerate of the fact that people have a personal life beyond organizational commitments. The facility of virtual connect is being overused, and the employees are expected to be available for work all the time. Thus, this causes a frequent violation of work–family boundaries.

Work–home Role Conflict

Participants reported conflicts responsibilities between home and office expectations. Employees had to be self-sufficient during the pandemic and do all the household works themselves. They realized that home responsibilities were important to execute, however, they also felt that there were several distractions at home such as home-schooling and elderly care. While concentrating on a virtual call, the employee also had to answer the doorbell for receiving groceries from the online delivery agent. Distractions were exacerbated if the participant's spouse was also working. Thus, there were frequent boundary clashes between home and work demands.

Our findings concur with the past research, which highlights the boundary violations that employees face as they home-based telework. There is a lack of spatiotemporal boundary, and work–family spillover is recurrent wherein most often work encroaches the family space and time (Cruz & Meisenbach, 2018; Derks et al., 2016; Nippert-Eng, 1996). Some individuals prefer segmentation of the work and family domains whereas others prefer integration (Derks et al., 2016; Varma et al., 2022). Thus, the boundary management process depends on how an individual perceives the relationship between the two roles, and 'the opportunities and resources that facilitate or deter boundary crossing' (Cruz & Meisenbach, 2018, p. 184). If individuals perceive the roles to be mutually exclusive, they will segment, i.e. maintain distinct time and space for work and family roles, whereas, people who integrate switch roles rapidly and execute different roles in the same space and time (Cruz & Meisenbach, 2018; Shumate & Fulk, 2004).

While technology has liberated people from space and time facilitating work from anywhere and at any time, it has also captured them in perpetual work (Malhotra, 2021). Technology transcended spatiotemporal boundaries, thus, creating greater opportunities for an integrated approach to boundary management. In the current situation when employees were forced to WFH, the notion of separate space and time for separate roles disappeared. Further, this permeable boundary was encroached by the technology-driven work. Individuals also succumbed to boundary violations,

which became a norm due to constraints (i.e. government-enforced lockdown) or perceived expectations of the employer (e.g. job security, drive to perform, demonstration of flexibility, commitment and loyalty).

Dimension 4: Employee Resilience

Faster Digital Adoption

While digitization has been on the cards for a long time, the adoption of technology was accelerated at an unprecedented pace during COVID-19 because technology was the only medium to stay connected with the outside world. Technology platforms on which the technology-enabled sectors were built became a boon for employees not only to continue their work but also with regard to job security as these sectors had a lower likelihood of employment loss. Employees of technology firms got an opportunity to grow and explore those tech-domains that they had not yet explored. By adopting digital means, employees coped with some of the challenges caused by WFH.

Adaptation of New Work Methods

While the policy of WFH existed in the pre-pandemic era, its practice was limited. The lockdowns due to the COVID-19 pandemic led to the identification of jobs that could be performed remotely, how work could be redesigned and different ways of collaboration. Despite the various challenges of boundary management, employees adapted to WFH and now vouch for the 'hybrid work model'. In a hybrid work model, employees will physically work from office premises for a few days a week and WFH for the remaining days. This model works in the favour of both employer and employee. From an employer's perspective, this model will save the infrastructure cost considerably, and from an employee's perspective, this will help employees to maintain a good balance between their personal and professional lives. Thus, new work modalities emerged from the forced WFH design.

Thrust on Upskilling

Another major contribution of WFH during the pandemic is the boost to employee upskilling. Due to the advent of the era of artificial intelligence, it was estimated that several jobs will be lost due to automation, especially in the technology space. This change necessitated employees to upskill themselves to stay relevant and employed. However, under normal circumstances, most people have natural inertia to change and wish to remain in their comfort zones. The crisis brought forth by COVID-19 provided ample opportunities for employees to upskill themselves either by joining online courses or attending online training programs. Several participants shared how they were trained online by their organizations to become more tech-savvy and become comfortable with advanced technology platforms. Employees were also trained on soft skills and future-oriented skills, such as flexibility and agility. These initiatives towards upskilling demonstrate that employees not only coped well with the challenging situation but also thrived in the adverse times.

Flexible Timing Driven Improved Quality of Life

Participants reported several personal benefits as they worked from home. Some of them shared that they could spend more time with their children and engage more actively in their school activities. The time that was typically spent commuting to the office was now being spent with the family, and family bonding was strengthening. Some participants also happily noted that they could revive their interests

and hobbies such as singing and cooking, thus, giving them a sense of fulfilment. This theme also indicates how employees went beyond adaptation to building a sense of mastery, purpose and self-enhancement.

Discussion

Theoretical Contributions

Our findings extend the current theoretical understanding of organizational influence on boundary control and management. In the pre-pandemic scenario, boundary management was largely an individual's prerogative as WFH was a choice. During the pandemic when WFH was involuntary, organizations had a major role to play in controlling the work–life relationships. Work time and workspace conveniently invaded personal time and personal space as organizations began exploiting the cross-domain boundary dynamics. This permeability of boundaries during the pandemic-induced WFH implies that effective boundary management does not rest solely with the individuals. It occurs in situ with the organization, i.e. management of individuals' personal-professional boundaries is nested in the organization's work–family culture. Further, while most boundary management studies focussed on segmentation and integration as the predominant boundary management styles, the pandemic highlighted the need for individuals to use 'alternating boundary management style', i.e. individuals may have different levels of focus on work, family or both and may enact different patterns of boundary management (Kossek & Lautsch, 2012, p. 154). There are not many studies that have explored the conditions under which alternating boundary management styles will be prevalent. Our findings highlight that crises such as business continuity during the COVID-19 pandemic bring alternating boundary management styles to the forefront, thus addressing the call for more research by Kossek & Lautsch (2012).

Second, though the blurring of boundaries created turmoil in the employees' lives, they had to find ways to cope. Since WFH during COVID-19 was the only way of functioning during the crisis, employees had to adapt to the uncertain situation. According to the theory of cognitive adaptation, when an individual is faced with threatening events, their adjustment process centres around meaning, mastery and self-enhancement. People search for meaning in the event/experience to understand why it happened, and what is its significance. People attempt to gain mastery over the event and try to manage or control it. Finally, individuals expend efforts to restore their self-esteem. In the present scenario, we believe that employees had to adapt cognitively due to the threatening event (the COVID-19 pandemic) that forced them to WFH.

Our study underscores that the employees not only adapted to the stress and uncertainty while working from home during the pandemic but also thrived and positively coped with the dynamic environment. This extends theories of adaptation to invoke the concept of 'resilience' (Kuntz et al., 2016). Resilience is not only an individual's capacity to adapt to adversity but also the ability to thrive in the face of adversity (Lamb & Cogan, 2016; Näswall et al., 2019). Resilience is best understood as a dynamic process of positive coping in times of significant adversity. When faced with challenging circumstances, employees develop a behavioural capacity to gather, integrate and utilize the available resources to continually adapt and flourish (Keeman et al., 2017; Kuntz et al., 2016). This signifies that employee resilience is a developable capability that requires an enabling context. Most often, a major crisis activates the ability of an employee to adapt and creates a context to express resilience towards improvement.

Practical Implications and Future Work

Since the present study was conducted among employees in the technology-enabled sectors, future studies should explore other sectoral set-ups to unearth how employees in other sectors adapted to forced WFH during COVID-19. Further, respondents shared that most of them may work in the hybrid mode in the post-pandemic era. Thus, further research on boundary management and adaptation is needed in the context of hybrid work. Nevertheless, the study findings have several practical implications for organizations.

First, balancing the boundaries between work and family domains is crucial for employees to work productively in a remote environment. Organizations need to address the paradox innate to flexible work enabled by technology (Rofcanin & Anand, 2020). The employee is digitally reachable for work regardless of time and location, so, how do employees deal with this permeability of boundaries between work and family roles? Such work practices are leading to perceptions of intensified work and imbalance between work and life. Research is needed on how to solve this paradox which may intensify with technological advancements and hybridization of work unless organizational metrics measure outcome-based productivity than the number of hours clocked in or provide employees with 'slack time' (e.g. Google, LinkedIn, Apple and Microsoft) to pursue passion-inspired activities (Malhotra, 2021). Thus, employers must respect the employee's need to demarcate personal and professional boundaries so that the employer–employee relationship continues healthily if the WFH situation prevails.

Second, employees are undergoing a lot of emotional and mental stress. Additionally, lack of adequate workspace at home, lack of adequate breaks and long hours spent in front of the screen are leading to technostress. Further, most employees long for the need for organizational identity and a sense of belongingness. In the virtual mode, it is important to see the extent to which an employee's need for belongingness and inclusion will be fulfilled. Thus, employee well-being will be a key dimension to be measured and addressed for smooth organizational functioning.

Third, disruptions and uncertainties in personal and professional lives were brought forth by the COVID-19 pandemic. Thus, underscoring the need for employees to build resilience. Building resilience among employees is the shared responsibility of employees and organizational leaders. The pandemic has increased the importance of a resilience-promoting organizational environment (Kuntz et al., 2016), for instance, resilient employee behaviours such as incorporating agility in processes, self-driven upskilling and thriving in a hybridized work set-up require organizational leaders to create an environment that fosters autonomy, accountability and a diverse workforce.

Conclusion

The COVID-19 pandemic triggered unprecedented changes in the lives of employees. For the first time in the history of employment, employees were forced to WFH at a massive scale. Personal and professional facets of life became intertwined leading to frequent and inevitable violation of boundaries. Employees faced tremendous stress due to work disruptions, isolation and intensified work that posed a threat to their well-being. However, the forced WFH during the pandemic also unearthed employees' ability to adapt and build resilience. Thus, organizational leaders must expend conscious efforts towards respecting work–family boundaries, enhancing employee well-being and building a resilience-promoting work environment.

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APPENDIX

Interview Schedule

1. How do you find the 'work from home' way of working?
2. What is the impact of virtual connect on you and your team?
3. How did you overcome the challenges (if any) while working from home?
4. How would you prefer to work in the future? Why?
5. Do you see anything positive from this crisis?
6. Please provide information related to your work location: pre-COVID-19 work location, current work location, is current location work from home/on-site/hybrid?
7. Please provide information related to your industry, gender, age, years of work experience (total), tenure in the current organization and current role (HR/Finance etc.).
8. Do you have home-schooling children? Is your spouse also working from home? Do your parents live together? How many rooms are there in your house?
9. Did you purchase any device (such as laptops)? Did you purchase any internet connection and/or power backup in order to smoothly work from home? Did you purchase any furniture in order to comfortably work from home?

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